



MILIND SHELTE

ON CLOUD NINE
Shreeyaa Pore with her award; left, a poster of her animated short, *Kali*

From the 750 finalists announced, 135 were declared winners of gold, silver and bronze honours. Flown down to Mumbai for the four-day summit, the finalists, ranging from 12 to 66 years, also got a brief audience with Prime Minister Narendra Modi on the inaugural day and displayed their work at Creatosphere, an innovation zone at the summit, where they could also network with industry professionals.

The star-studded ceremony, held on May 2 at the Jio World Convention Centre, included the likes of Aamir, Mithun Chakraborty, Nagarjuna, Vikrant Massey, Anupam Kher and Prasoon Joshi, and saw the 135 beaming winners walk away with trophies and prize money. "This journey has only just begun," said Union I&B minister Ashwini Vaishnaw to the gathered audience of creators. "With this initiative, you are stepping into a world of new opportunities." Vaishnaw further informed them that the government has committed to set up an Indian Institute of Creative Technology [IICT], a platform for "innovation and expression".

Joining Vaishnaw among political dignitaries was Maharashtra chief minister Devendra Fadnavis, who has allocated land for the IICT. "Our PM's dream to see India on top of the creator economy comes alive when I see all of you here," said Fadnavis. "WAVES may be on for four days, but I feel that it started when all of you accepted this [Create in India] challenge and succeeded with all of you sending in your entries. I hope your creativity flourishes, you get more inspiration and, in this creative ecosystem, you hit new highs."

"I HAVE BEEN TO MANY COSPLAY CONTESTS, BUT I GOT GOOSEBUMPS WHEN I WENT ON STAGE AT WAVES. I WAS LIKE...'WHAT THE HELL IS HAPPENING!'. IT WAS A BIG PLATFORM FOR ME"

SAMEER SHAIKH
Winner, Cosplay Championship

MUCH-NEEDED VALIDATION

At least one winner felt the recognition (accompanied by a Rs 1 lakh prize) gave him the encouragement and validation he desperately needed. Noida-based Gautam Pahwa, 38, had dabbled in a host of professions—from being a dive instructor and working on a cruise, to carpentry and running an Airbnb in Goa—before he bought his first drone three years ago. He hasn't looked back since. "I can see myself doing this for a long time; it enables me to use my creative side and intelligence," says Pahwa, who has also built his own drones and learned how to operate them, using the internet as his guide. Pahwa's entry in the aerial cinematics category, 'India: A Bird's Eye View', shot using drones), saw him showcase India's stunning locales from his many travels, particularly to coastal areas. "As a content creator, you have anxiety," he says. Working with drones, Pahwa says, is like "playing with toys and trying to figure them out. This will help a lot of people who want to do something [as content creator]".



"I WANTED MY SHORT *KALI* TO BE SHOWN ON A BIG PLATFORM LIKE WAVES. CONNECTING WITH OTHER ANIMATORS WAS JUST AMAZING"

SHREEYAA PORE
Winner, Animation Challenge

Most winners were emerging talent like Sameer Shaikh, who came down from Maharashtra's Latur and discovered on the day of the awards that he was the winner of the Cosplay Championship. For the challenge, Shaikh made the costume of Odin Infernal